

144 PB storage

Compact Flash Association has unveiled the Compact Flash 5.0 specification which has a theoretical maximum capacity of 144 peta bytes

Transcend StoreJet 35T

Transcend launches StoreJet 35T capable of transferring at 42MB/s at Rs. 14,000 for the 1.5TB drive.

The Shoe Spa

Shining the world, one pair at a time

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It's easy to take a shine to Tabish Ahsan and Saral Budhiraja. They are young, ambitious and have a definite spring in their step. The happy feet aren't surprising considering Ahsan and Budhiraja run The Shoe Spa, a specialised shoe cleaning and shoe repair service they founded in July 2009.

The Shoe Spa claims to transform old shoes into a shining new pair. The process, which the young promoters guard zealously, includes several steps like conditioning, massaging and moisturising to keep your soles soaring. Little wonder then that the company tagline reads, "We don't just clean your shoes, we give them a spa".

Management graduates from the Indian Institute of Planning and Management, Delhi, Ahsan and Budhiraja, were not groomed to fill these shoes. When they passed out together in April 2009, they were buffed up for lucrative corporate careers. Through campus placements, 22-year-old Ahsan bagged a job with a tourism and retail management company, while 23-year-old Budhiraja was set to join a market research firm. But, both their employers kept deferring joining dates.

The idle time allowed innovative rethink. Budhiraja had been toying with the idea of setting up a shoe cleaning business and felt this was a good time to step in. "Shoes aren't a necessity item now. They are about luxury, indulgence and making a style statement. I was sure people would pay to preserve their favourite pair." The spa, he believes, caters to this loophole in the market. One evening, he called Ahsan, a close friend from business school, to pitch his idea. "He asked me if I would pay Rs 50 to get my sneakers cleaned. I said no way. And told him nobody else would either," laughs Ahsan.

Budhiraja's prodding soon converted

him, and the duo began an interesting journey of experimentation. They trawled through upmarket shopping streets and dingy, crowded wholesale markets in Karol Bagh to discover the best cleansing items.

Equipped with some of their find, they used their family for market research and pleaded with them to pass up their shoes. They charged Rs 50 at first but quickly hiked that to Rs 80 and then to Rs 100 as they got better.

Convinced they could give old pairs a new lease, Ahsan and Budhiraja once again turned to family, this time for seed fund, to set up a workshop in Noida.

They began operations with Rs 3.5 lakh to buy equipment, get a website up, and print branded flyers and shopping bags. The first 15,000 flyers were distributed in Noida's posh Sector 15A. "Nothing happened the first two or three days. There were no calls. But, suddenly we started getting customers," says Ahsan.

Nearly two lakh flyers later and a service that has expanded to Delhi, The Shoe Spa now gets 15-20 pairs of shoes daily. In fact, in October 2009, the duo got more than 50 shoe orders in a single day.

A basic shoe spa is the signature treatment. Shoe moisturising, shoe waterproofing and shoe repair services are also on offer.

Customers can call them or leave a message on their website (www.theshoespa.in) to buy these services. A delivery boy brings the shoes to the workshop, which was shifted to Civil Lines in September to serve Delhi neighbourhoods better. A diagnosis is arrived at.

"We call the customer to tell them

what's needed," Budhiraja explains. A basic shoe spa costs between Rs 150 and Rs 225. Each add-on service is additionally priced. Ahsan and Budhiraja now employ around five people, mainly cobblers and a supervisor, to run the workshop.

Over the last six months, Ahsan and Budhiraja have put in around Rs 5 lakh into the business. But, recovery and profit maximisation are not a big concern for now. "We don't charge our customers if they are not satisfied. We want to deliver the best quality. We learn every day and we improve every day," says Ahsan.

On the heels of that sentiment though is a quiet confidence. "The Shoe Spa is going to be a big brand if we can survive the next couple of years. We want it to



Sporting Happy Feet Tabish Ahsan (L) and Saral Budhiraja hope to improve their online order system in the next three months.

be all over India. The expansion will happen," Budhiraja asserts.

A bigger workshop, more new machinery and an improved online order system are the definite goal posts for the next three months. Ahsan and Budhiraja think they can manage much of this with little outside help.

They are wary of "doing PR" and want to grow as organically as possible. Although they have started talking about a bank loan recently, they haven't worked on a business plan geared to seek organised funding. **d**